

Scenario 3

You are the founder of a direct-to-consumer kelp noodle company. Although you believe kelp noodles are a popular trend and a healthy alternative to spaghetti, you've gotten very little traction so far. You've worked for seven years, spent your own money on the business (money you saved up from your previous job), but haven't been able to raise any outside capital. You have \$13,000 in the bank after starting with \$216,000. What would you do?

This is the scenario new entrepreneurs worry about. What if you spend years trying to launch a new business but you wake up on April 19 distressed and almost broke?

That's the moment you lie in bed muttering, "How the fuck did I get here? I used to have \$216,000 in savings. I was doing great. My job was fine, I had time for my friends, and I was fifteen pounds lighter. What did I do? Who did I think I was? Why did I have to start this company?"

It's the beginning of a dark path. People then start beating themselves up and sinking under the weight of past decisions.

Worst of all, they start blaming others, which makes the problem significantly worse. "Why did GaryVee have to tell me to be an entrepreneur? All these fucking people on Instagram ... Why did my dad push me to do this? Why did my mom not stop me this time?"

People quickly start pointing fingers. But if you're in this scenario, pointing your thumb back at yourself is what will keep you positive that morning of April 19:

I really wanted to see if I could do this. It was ultimately my decision. I'm running out of savings now, but I'm grateful I gave it a shot.

When you're eighty-three years old, you're going to be ecstatic about the seven years you spent building this business. You clearly quit your day job for a reason. If you had stayed and collected that paycheck, you might have more money, but you'd be crushed by the what-if.

The what-if is poison. It's a source of regret and emotional pain in your old age. As soon as you wake up and start going down a bad path, call an audible fast:

No, it's not anybody's fault that I'm down to my last \$13,000 from \$216,000. I'm grateful. I'm happy I did this, because I'm not going to feel regret in my old age.

People always debate over what the "right" decision in a situation like this. Should you lean into humility and go back to your day job? Or should you stick to your conviction and keep trying until your savings run to \$0? Let's play it out together.

OPTION 1: You decide to go back to your day job in law, a field that doesn't excite you.

OK, so you want to stack up some more savings.

When you step back into the office, you'll have to deploy a crazy dose of humility. You'll have to talk to that work friend who made a snarky comment that your business would fail. You'll have to admit your friend was right. Your mom might have never come out and said it, but you know she was never on board with the idea either. You'll have to talk to her too.

Let's make option 1 even tougher: nineteen months after you went back to your day job, kelp noodles spiked in popularity after a few famous YouTube

influencers made videos about them, and a major health report came out that caught America's attention. Suddenly, your number-three competitor, who was lagging behind you, ends up dominating market share. You watch Kraft Foods buy your competitor's company for \$200 million.

If you choose option 1 and this happens, you'd need humility and gratitude to protect yourself against dwelling and self-criticism. You needed to give this opportunity a shot. Even though you didn't win, you got to try for seven years — so much more than most people ever get.

Alternatively, option 1 could play out the opposite way. Kelp noodles may never become mainstream. Your competitors may also fail. You may go back to your law-firm job, build your savings back up, and meet a new lifelong friend at the company. Maybe your friend invites you to an event where you meet your future spouse or a fellow parent whose child becomes your child's best friend.

Success in business is just one part of life. What if your kelp noodle company failed, but your personal life actually improved?

You can't predict the events that give you the best overall outcome in life. That's why I love leaning into optimism. Even if I missed out on a huge investment opportunity, who knows what would've happened if I'd gotten it? What if getting that opportunity meant I would have to fly across the world to give a conference, and on the way my plane crashed, and I died? What if I actually avoided a catastrophe because I missed out on a deal?

In January 2020, we all got the devastating news that Kobe Bryant and eight other people had died in a helicopter crash. If America's COVID-19 lockdowns had started in January 2020 instead of March, would they still be alive today? Imagine, that tragic event might never have happened.

That's how I think about it. You don't know if an event is "good" or "bad" because you never know the alternative. Quitting your business might have led you to something incredible (like a lifelong friendship) or helped you avoid something horrible (like an accident or a disease). I prefer to look at life through the lens of optimism.

OPTION 2: You stick with your kelp noodle company until your savings completely run out.

Going to zero is a very lonely feeling. Countless people have gone to Atlantic City or Las Vegas with \$400, got down to \$80, dreamed of turning that \$80 back to \$400, went to zero, and had to borrow money from their friends to get a cab.

In this scenario, your last \$13,000 in savings will likely end up going to zero.

But I'm asking you: When you're seventy-one, will you feel better about yourself for going all the way to zero before going back to your law-firm job, or will you feel better about saving that \$13,000?

Cutting your losses is important, but limiting regret is important too. Even if kelp noodles never become mainstream, your competitors never explode in growth, and Kraft Foods never makes a \$200 million acquisition in the space, you can feel proud at seventy-one that you left it all on the field.

There is no right decision here, which depends on your own goals in this scenario, but here's my ultimate point:

If you look at every decision you make through the lens of optimism and layer it with kindness to yourself, there's almost never a wrong decision. If you look at it through pessimism, there are problems with every decision. That's

why I'm always happy in the grand scheme of things.

Scenario 3 Follow-Up Question:

"My natural instinct is to be pessimistic rather than optimistic. How do I fix that?"

By hanging out with optimistic people. The more time you spend with practical, optimistic people, the more you'll shift your mind-set.